

Server Training Manual

Sample document. Tap and Burger, a neighborhood burger and beer house

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Tap & Burger | A Neighborhood Burger and Beer House

This is a sample deliverable built for a casual, multi location burger and beer concept. It is written to be used as is by a new server, and to double as a template you can adapt for any client. Replace the concept name, the menu specifics, and the point of sale name with the real ones, and it is ready to hand out.

Welcome to the team

Welcome. You are joining a neighborhood spot where people come to relax, eat a great burger, and feel at home. That feeling is your job. The food and the beer get them in the door. You are the reason they come back.

This manual teaches you how we do things here, step by step. Read it once all the way through. Keep it nearby for your first two weeks. By the end of training you will know our steps of service, our menu, and our standards well enough to run a section on your own with confidence.

You do not have to memorize everything today. You just have to care, pay attention, and follow the steps. We will teach you the rest.

Who we are

We are a casual burger and beer house. Think great burgers, a serious tap list, cold beer poured right, and service that is warm and quick without being stiff. We are not fine dining and we are not a chain. We are the neighborhood's living room.

Three things define us.

1. **Genuine warmth.** We treat guests like we are glad they came, because we are.
 2. **Speed that feels easy.** Casual does not mean slow. Drinks come fast, food comes hot, and nobody waits wondering where you went.
 3. **Consistency.** A guest gets the same great experience whether they come on a Tuesday or a Saturday, and at any of our locations.
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What we expect from you

These are the standards. They are simple and they are not optional.

- Be on time, in clean uniform, ready to work at your scheduled start.
- Know the menu. Guests trust your recommendations.

- Greet every table within one minute of being seated.
 - Never let a guest sit with an empty glass and no plan for a refill.
 - Keep your section clean and reset as you go.
 - Check ID for every alcohol order that looks under 30.
 - Tell a manager right away about any complaint, spill, injury, or guest who has had too much to drink.
 - Leave your closing side work done right for the next shift.
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Your look

You represent us the moment a guest sees you.

- Clean, pressed uniform per your location's standard. Clean closed toe non slip shoes.
- Hair neat and pulled back if long. Hands and nails clean. Light scent or none.
- A clean apron with a working pen, a wine key, and your order pad or tablet.
- A name people can read and a smile they can see.

If you ever spill on yourself, change or clean up before you return to the floor.

Before your shift

Every shift starts the same way.

1. **Clock in** at your scheduled time, not before, not after.
2. **Check the board.** Read the daily notes. Learn the 86 list, which is the list of items we are out of. Learn the features and any beers that just tapped or just kicked.
3. **Set your station.** Stock your service area. Check that you have menus, clean glassware, rolled silverware, to go boxes, and clean rags.
4. **Walk your section.** Wipe and level every table. Check chairs, condiments, and that each table is set to standard.
5. **Taste and learn.** If there is a new menu item or a new beer, ask to taste it or learn its description so you can sell it honestly.

When the doors open, you are ready, not still setting up.

Know your floor

You cannot give fast service if you do not know where things are.

- Learn your **table numbers** and your **section** cold. You should be able to picture every table with your eyes closed.
 - Learn the **path** from your section to the kitchen window, the bar, the dish area, the to go station, and the restrooms.
 - Learn where backups live: silverware, napkins, kid supplies, condiments, glassware, and to go materials.
 - Know which tables are yours, which are shared, and who your support team is, meaning your bartender, your food runner, and your busser.
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The steps of service

This is the heart of the job. Every guest, every time, in this order. Learn these like a recipe.

1. The greet, within one minute.

Get to the table within one minute of them sitting down. Smile, say hello, welcome them. If you are slammed, at least make eye contact and say "I will be right with you." A guest who has been seen will wait. A guest who feels invisible will not.

2. Drinks first.

Take the drink order right away. Suggest something specific. "Our hazy IPA just tapped and it is drinking great, want me to bring you one." Always offer water. Check ID on any alcohol order that looks under 30.

3. Deliver drinks and read the table.

Bring drinks fast. As you set them down, read the table. Are they ready to order, or do they need a minute. Are they here for a quick lunch or a long hangout. Match your pace to theirs.

4. Guide the food order.

Know the menu well enough to guide them. Ask if anyone has allergies. Make honest recommendations. If they are unsure, point to a favorite. "The classic cheeseburger is what we are known for, you cannot go wrong." Repeat the order back so it is correct. Note temperatures for burgers and any modifications clearly.

5. Fire and time the food.

Put the order in correctly the first time. Note any course timing, like apps first. A wrong or mistimed order is the most common service failure, and it is avoidable.

6. Check back, the two bite rule.

Return about two bites after the food lands. Not before, not ten minutes later. Ask how everything tastes and fix anything that is wrong before it becomes a complaint. Refill drinks. Never walk past

your table empty handed and never walk to the kitchen empty handed.

7. Pre bus and maintain.

Clear finished plates and empty glasses as you go. Keep the table clean. Watch drink levels. A guest should never have to flag you down for a refill or a clear plate.

8. Dessert and the last round.

Before they ask for the check, offer one more thing. A dessert, one more beer, a coffee. This is good service and it grows the check naturally. Offer, do not push.

9. The check.

Drop the check promptly once they seem ready, but never make them feel rushed out. Be ready to run the payment quickly. Thank them by name if you have it.

10. The farewell and reset.

Thank them warmly and invite them back. "Thanks for coming in, hope to see you again soon." Then reset the table fast and to standard so it is ready for the next guests.

Menu knowledge

Guests trust you. You cannot guide them if you do not know the menu. Learn these.

- **The burgers.** Know every burger, what is on it, and what makes it special. Know which is the classic, which is the spicy one, which is the loaded one, and which is the veggie or plant based option.
- **Temperatures.** Know how we cook burgers and always ask the guest how they want theirs. Know which items cannot be cooked to order.
- **Builds and swaps.** Know what can be added, removed, or swapped, and what cannot.
- **Sides and shareables.** Know the fries, the apps, the salads, and what pairs well with what.
- **Kids and dietary.** Know the kids options, the vegetarian and vegan options, and the gluten conscious options.
- **Allergens.** Know the common allergens in our top items: dairy, gluten, egg, soy, nuts, shellfish. When in doubt, ask the kitchen. Never guess on an allergy.

Spend your first shifts tasting and learning. A server who can describe a burger in one mouthwatering sentence sells more and tips better.

Beer and tap knowledge

We are a tap house. Beer is part of who we are. You do not need to be an expert on day one, but you do need the basics.

- **Know the styles on tap.** Be able to say, in plain words, what each beer is. "This one is a light, crisp lager, easy to drink. This one is a hoppy IPA, more bitter and citrusy. This one is a dark stout, roasty, like coffee."
- **Make a fast recommendation.** When a guest says "I like light beers," you should have an answer ready.
- **Pour and present right.** Learn your location's pour standard, the right glass for each beer, and how to carry and set a full pint without spilling or over touching the rim.
- **Know what just tapped and what just kicked.** Nothing is worse than selling a beer that is out.
- **Flights.** Know if we offer flights and how to build one for someone who wants to explore.

If a guest wants something you do not know, it is always okay to say "let me grab the exact details for you" and ask the bartender. Honest beats made up.

Serving alcohol responsibly

This protects the guest, you, and the house. It is not optional.

- **Check ID** for anyone ordering alcohol who looks under 30. Look at the birth date and the expiration. If it looks fake or the photo does not match, do not serve, and tell a manager.
- **Watch for intoxication.** Slurred speech, unsteady movement, getting loud or aggressive, ordering faster than they can handle. If you see signs, slow it down and tell a manager.
- **You can say no.** You are allowed and expected to refuse service to someone who has had too much. Always involve a manager so you are not alone in it.
- **Never serve a minor,** and never serve someone you believe is buying for a minor.
- **Hold your local certification** if your area requires one. Keep it current.

When in doubt, get a manager. You will never be in trouble for being careful.

Handling problems and complaints

Things go wrong. How you handle it is what guests remember.

The simple rule is **listen, own it, fix it, tell a manager.**

1. **Listen** fully. Do not argue or explain. Let them say it.

2. **Own it.** "I am so sorry, let me make that right." Even if it was not your fault, you are the face of the house right now.
3. **Fix it fast.** Replace the dish, remake the drink, do whatever it takes to turn the moment around.
4. **Tell a manager** right away on anything beyond a simple fix. A comp, an upset guest, an allergy mistake, a spill or injury. Managers want to know early, not after the guest has left angry.

A well handled problem can turn an unhappy guest into a regular. A hidden problem turns into a bad review.

Using the point of sale

(Replace with your location's system, for example Toast, Aloha, Revel, or Square.)

- Log in with your own code. Never use someone else's.
- Open a table, enter seat numbers if we use them, and ring items to the right seat.
- Enter temperatures, modifiers, and allergy notes clearly. The kitchen only knows what you ring.
- Fire courses in the right order.
- Run payment accurately. Repeat the total back. Handle cash per the cash handling procedure and never leave a drawer open.
- Close every check before you leave. An open check at close is a problem for everyone.

Ask for a full walkthrough on your first shift. Practice until it is second nature, because fumbling at the screen slows your whole section.

Closing and side work

The shift is not over when your last table leaves. Closing right is part of the job and the next shift depends on it.

- Finish all assigned side work: stocking, rolling silverware, wiping and resetting tables, cleaning your station.
- Restock for the next shift so they walk into a ready floor, the same way you want to.
- Complete your checkout with a manager. Cash out accurately and honestly.
- Do your closing cleaning duties fully. Cutting corners at close is the fastest way to lose trust.
- Clock out only when your work is actually done and a manager has checked you out.

Leave it the way you would want to find it.

How to be a great server here

The steps get you to good. These get you to great.

- **Anticipate.** A great server brings the refill before it is asked for and the napkins before the burger arrives.
 - **Sell honestly.** Recommend what you love. Offer the extra beer and the dessert. Guests want to be guided, not pressured.
 - **Work as a team.** Run food for other servers. Help bus. The floor wins together. Your tips go up when the whole room runs well.
 - **Watch the whole section, not one table.** Keep your eyes moving. Catch the raised hand before it becomes a wave.
 - **Reset your energy.** Hard table, rough moment, bad tip. Shake it off and walk to the next table fresh. Every table is a new chance.
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Your training schedule

Training runs about five shifts. Your trainer will guide you. Here is the plan.

- **Shift 1. Shadow.** Follow your trainer. Watch the steps of service in action. Learn the floor and the point of sale basics.
- **Shift 2. Learn the menu and beer.** Taste and study. Start carrying drinks and running food.
- **Shift 3. Take a few tables** with your trainer backing you up.
- **Shift 4. Run a small section** mostly on your own, trainer nearby.
- **Shift 5. Run a full section.** Your trainer and a manager confirm you are ready.

You move at the pace that gets you confident. There is no prize for rushing.

Training sign off

Both you and your trainer or manager sign when you can do each item without help.

Server name: _____ Start date: _____

- ☐ Knows the floor, table numbers, and section
- ☐ Knows the point of sale: open, ring, modify, fire, pay, close
- ☐ Knows the full menu, builds, swaps, and allergens
- ☐ Knows the beer styles on tap and can recommend
- ☐ Performs all ten steps of service consistently
- ☐ Checks ID correctly and knows responsible service rules
- ☐ Handles a complaint with listen, own, fix, tell a manager
- ☐ Completes opening setup to standard
- ☐ Completes closing side work and checkout to standard

Server signature: _____ Date: _____

Trainer signature: _____ Date: _____

Manager signature: _____ Date: _____

Welcome to the team. Now go take care of some people.